

Pre-Market Checklist

The exact routine professional traders follow before the market opens every day.

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What you do before the market opens determines the quality of your trading day. A structured pre-market routine eliminates reactive decision-making, keeps you focused on your best setups, and ensures you never enter the open unprepared.

6:00 – 7:00 AM

Overnight Review

Check overnight futures (ES, NQ). Look at any major gap up or gap down. Read news headlines for anything that moved markets overnight — earnings, macro data, geopolitical events. Note the pre-market high and low on your key watchlist names.

7:00 – 8:00 AM

News and Catalysts

Check your news sources for any stocks with significant pre-market volume. Look for earnings, FDA decisions, major analyst upgrades or downgrades, and any sector-moving news. These are your potential day trades and gap plays.

8:00 – 9:00 AM

Build Your Watchlist

Narrow your pre-market scans down to 3-5 names maximum. More than 5 and you are not watching — you are reacting. For each name, identify: the key level, your entry trigger, your stop, and your target. Know the plan before the bell.

9:00 – 9:30 AM

Final Prep

Check the VIX. Check SPY and QQQ pre-market levels. Set your alerts. Review your game plan one more time. Make sure your risk parameters are set. Do not adjust your plan after the open unless the thesis changes entirely.

PRE-MARKET CHECKLIST

- Futures checked — note gap direction and size
- Overnight news reviewed — no surprises
- Economic calendar checked — know what data drops today
- Watchlist finalized — 3 to 5 names maximum
- Entry, stop, and target defined for each setup
- VIX checked — adjust aggression accordingly
- Alerts set on key levels
- Daily max loss limit confirmed

Consistency in your pre-market routine is a competitive edge. Most retail traders open their platform at 9:29 AM with no plan. You will not be one of them.

